Unless and until you have fought out the issues of interpretation one by one with Bohr, I won't feel happy about the conclusions to be drawn from a piece of work as far reaching as yours. Please go (and see me too each way if you can!). So in one way your thesis is all done; in another way, the hardest part of the work is just beginning.… How soon can you come?" The last few sentences in the letter must have been unpleasant for Everett, who had already lined up a job in operations research at the Pentagon starting three weeks later, on the assumption that (as Wheeler had previously told him) his thesis would be accepted and his degree granted by the end of the summer.

But Bohr, Petersen, and others in Copenhagen were less enthusiastic about Everett's ideas than Wheeler thought. "There are some notions of Everett's that seem to lack meaningful content, as, for example, his universal wave function," wrote Alexander Stern, an American physicist studying with Bohr at the time, who had taken on the task of giving a seminar on Everett's work in front of Bohr and the rest of the institute. Stern's letter gives a sense of the attitude in Copenhagen toward Everett's ideas. "The basic shortcoming in his method of approach of his erudite, but inconclusive and indefinite paper is his lack of an adequate understanding of the measuring process. Everett does not seem to appreciate the FUNDAMENTALLY irreversible character and the FINALITY of a macroscopic measurement.… [I]t is an INDEFINABLE interaction." Stern went on to claim, without further explanation, that there was no contradiction between the Schrödinger equation and wave function collapse—that the measurement problem was not a problem at all—and that Everett's claim that there was such a contradiction was "not tenable." Ultimately, he dismissed Everett's ideas as either "a matter of theology" or "metaphysics," since the extra worlds postulated by Everett could never be seen or perceived directly in any way.

Despite the dim view that Copenhagen took of Everett's work, Wheeler still wanted the universal wave function and its promise of a quantum cosmology. To get Bohr's imprimatur, then, the words that went along with the universal wave function would have to change to better match the Copenhagen interpretation. Wheeler hoped for a way to retain what he liked in Everett's ideas while still using Copenhagen's language. His next letter to